



The Phoenicians first introduced this distinctive “black-on-red” pottery to Cyprus. This ox-shaped flask dates from c. 700 BCE, by which time the Cypriots had evolved their own version of the style.



This beautiful gold band was found at Enkomi on Cyprus, ancient Alashiya, and once decorated a luxurious garment. It dates to the 13th century BCE, when Enkomi was a major port on the world’s trade routes—clear from the band’s mix of Middle Eastern and Mycenaean Greek motifs.



Skilled seafarers and navigators, the Phoenicians built sophisticated multi-oared galleys (as on this coin from Sidon) designed to speed over vast distances, and made great contributions to shipbuilding technology. They probably developed a *bireme* with two banks of oars, the main warship in the 700s BCE.



This relief from the palace of the Assyrian king Sargon II (721–704 BCE) in Khorsabad (North Iraq) shows a wood shipment being unloaded. Assyria imported top-quality cedar for its palace building from Lebanon.



Further development of Phoenician and Arabian trading empires saw an even greater emphasis on travel by sea.

WARSHIP TECHNOLOGY

Warships were powered by a combination of sails and rowers, and by the 600s BCE, when the Phoenicians supplied vessels to the Persians for their battles with the Greeks **93 >>**, *biremes* (ships with two banks of oars) had been replaced by *triremes* (ships with three banks of oars).

GREAT EXPLORATIONS

There are many tales of the Phoenicians’ incredible long-distance voyages. Herodotus, the ancient Greek historian **<< 102–03**, wrote that in around 600 BCE, a Phoenician expedition sent down the Red Sea by Egyptian pharaoh Necho II sailed around Africa and returned through the “Pillars of Hercules” (the Straits of Gibraltar) in three years.

ARAB KINGDOMS

In the southwest of the Arabian peninsula, the **kingdom of the Himyarites** eclipsed that of the Sabaeans by the 3rd century CE and remained the dominant Arabian state until the 500s. Its trading ships plied regular routes along the East African coast, creating strong links between Africa and the Mediterranean. It exported African ivory to the Roman Empire and maintained a brisk trade in precious resins such as frankincense and myrrh.



HIMYARITE
RELIEF
CARVING

MARITIME SPICE ROUTES

From the 1st millennium BCE onward, the Arabs’ spice and incense **routes started bypassing the desert** in favor of travel by sea.

The kingdom of Saba (biblical Sheba, as in the queen of Sheba) held considerable sway in the Arabian Peninsula by the 8th century BCE. Ma’rib city was its center—a major post along the Arabian incense road.